

POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE CONTRIBUTIONS TO THE RELATIONSHIP: MINE AND YOURS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Each partner identifies the positive things he/she and the partner contribute to the relationship.
2. Each partner identifies changes he/she and the partner should make to improve the relationship.
3. Establish a balanced perspective on the relationship rather than focusing on partner's negatives.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Female Sexual Dysfunction
- Male Sexual Dysfunction

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

This exercise has a separate page to be filled out by each of the partners in the relationship. Ask each partner to complete the exercise independently and to bring it to a subsequent conjoint session. Review each partner's list and attempt to clarify the language and to put the changes requested in positive terms. Clients generally indicate what they would like not to happen rather than what they would like to happen. Ask each client for a commitment to work on making the changes that are called for in his/her own behavior.

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GENERAL INTRODUCTION FOR BOTH PARTNERS

When conflicts predominate in a relationship, an exaggerated focus gets placed on the negative aspects of the partner. Defenses keep us from evaluating our own contributions to the conflict and from noticing the positive things that the partner does to enhance the relationship. We become so focused on the negative aspects and primarily see the partner as the cause of the failure of the relationship. This assignment attempts to put things in perspective by asking each partner to take an honest look at himself/herself as well as evaluating the partner's contribution to conflict. Additional balance is sought by attempting to have each partner list the positive things that are brought to the relationship by each partner.

Partner 1 List

Complete each of the following four lists. In the first list, itemize those things that you do that contribute positively to the relationship. In the second list, itemize those things that your partner does that enhance the relationship. Third, list the things that you need to do to improve the relationship and make it stronger. Finally (and this is always the easiest part), list the things that you believe your partner needs to do to make the relationship better.

1. What I do to enhance the relationship:

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

2. What does my partner do to enhance the relationship?

- A. _____
- B. _____

- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

3. Things I need to do to improve the relationship:

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

4. What does my partner need to do to make the relationship better?

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

Partner 2 List

Complete each of the following four lists. In the first list, itemize those things that you do that contribute positively to the relationship. In the second list, itemize those things that your partner does that enhance the relationship. Third, list the things that you need to do to improve the relationship and make it stronger. Finally (and this is always the easiest part), list the things that you believe your partner needs to do to make the relationship better.

1. What I do to enhance the relationship:

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

2. What does my partner do to enhance the relationship?

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

3. Things I need to do to improve the relationship:

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____

4. What does my partner need to do to make the relationship better?

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____
- D. _____
- E. _____